

Joy in Every Circumstance

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Written by Daniel Tesfamariam

Ages 10-17

Little Believers Tigrinya Bible Stories

Book 64 of 80

Scene 1 of 25

[PICTURE: Paul sitting in a dimly lit Roman prison cell, chained to a guard, yet writing on a scroll with a peaceful smile on his face. A small oil lamp illuminates the parchment. Through a tiny window, the Roman skyline is visible. His expression radiates unexpected joy despite the chains. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

Picture this: a man in chains, locked in a Roman prison, awaiting a trial that could end in his execution. You would expect despair, bitterness, or at least complaint. But instead, the apostle Paul picks up his pen and writes a letter so overflowing with joy that it has been called "the epistle of joy." The word "joy" or "rejoice" appears sixteen times in just four short chapters. Paul is writing to the church at Philippi — believers he loves deeply, people who supported him when no one else would. From his prison cell, Paul doesn't write about his suffering or beg for sympathy. He writes about joy. Not happiness — which depends on what happens to you — but joy, which is rooted in something far deeper than circumstances. This letter will challenge everything you think you know about what it means to be content.

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(Izi HisebO: hade seb'ay bisenselat te'asiru, ab nay Roma bet ma'iserti te'ats'iyu, bimot kiwida'e zikhil firdi yits'be alo. Tesfa miqurats', mired, wey biwihidu tir'an

*tits'be. Gina ab kindi'u hawarya Pawlos bir'u ali'ilu biHagos zifesis debdabe yits'Hif —
"nay Hagos mel'ikhti" tebahilu zits'wa'e. Pawlos nab betekristyan Filipi yits'Hif —
bizuH zefqirom aminti, kali'ot ab zeydegfwo gize zidegefwo sebat.)*

Scene 2 of 25

[PICTURE: A split scene showing three founding stories of the Philippian church: Lydia at the riverside in purple robes being baptized, the Philippian jailer kneeling before Paul and Silas in the earthquake-damaged prison, and a young slave girl being set free from a spirit. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

The church at Philippi had an extraordinary origin. It began with three unlikely converts: Lydia, a wealthy businesswoman who sold expensive purple cloth; a Roman jailer who was about to kill himself when an earthquake opened the prison doors; and a slave girl who had been exploited for her fortune-telling abilities until Paul set her free. What a diverse beginning! A rich woman, a desperate jailer, and a freed slave — the gospel brought them all together into one family. This church became Paul's most generous and faithful supporters. They sent him money when he was in need, they sent Epaphroditus to care for him in prison, and they never abandoned him when other churches did. Their love was not just words — it was action. Paul called them his "joy and crown." Now, years later, he writes back to them with a message they desperately need to hear.

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(Betekristyan Filipi fluiy mebeqol nebera. Biseleste zeytits'biyi aminti jemeret: Lidya habtam negadit kibur hibri lila cherqi tisheyiT zineberet; hade Romawi halawi bet ma'iserti midre-minqiTqaT ma'itso bet ma'iserti mis kefeto ri'su kiqetil ziqerebe; kemu'win hanti barya gwal biTinqola ki'leta timzimez zineberet Pawlos nets'a zewits'a. Kemey zibele bizuHnet zelew mejemerta! Habtam sebeiyti, tesfa ziqoretse halawi, nets'a ziwets'et barya — wengel nikulom ab hanti sidra awehahdom.)

[PICTURE: Paul in his prison cell, eyes closed in prayer with a gentle smile, hands lifted as far as chains allow. Above his head, a thought bubble shows the faces of the Philippian believers — men, women, and young people gathered together in worship. Warm golden light surrounds the memory. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

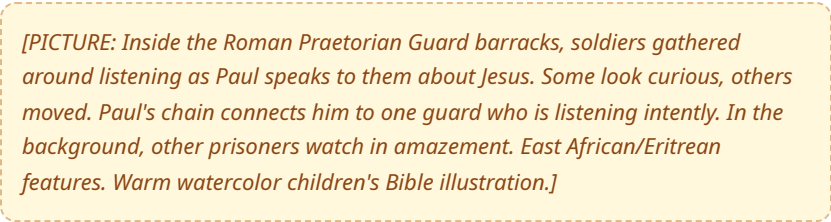
"I thank my God every time I remember you. In all my prayers for all of you, I always pray with joy." What a remarkable statement from a man in prison! Paul doesn't begin his letter with complaints about his situation or requests for rescue. He begins with gratitude and joy — specifically, gratitude for people. Notice what fuels Paul's joy: not comfort, not freedom, not success, but relationships. He thanks God for the Philippians' partnership in the gospel from the very first day until now. True joy is never found in isolation. It is discovered in community, in shared purpose, in loving others more than yourself. Paul models something profound here: even in your darkest moments, gratitude for the people God has placed in your life can become a wellspring of joy that no prison can contain.

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(Ab zizekerukukum kulu gize ni'Amlakhey emesgín. Ab kulu tselotey nikulkhum kulu gize biHagos its'lyelkum. Ab bet ma'iserti kab zelo seb kemey zibele zegerim qal! Pawlos debdab'u biTir'an biza'iba kunetatu wey biTiyaqe midhan ayjimirin —

*bimisiganan Hagosín yijmir — bijflay misgana nisebat. NiHagos Pawlos ziqisqis
astebhil: micho'ot aykonen, harnet aykonen, awet aykonen — zimdnatat iyu.)*

Scene 4 of 25



Paul makes a stunning declaration: "What has happened to me has actually served to advance the gospel." Think about that. He's not saying his imprisonment doesn't matter or that suffering is enjoyable. He's saying that God has taken what his enemies meant for evil and turned it into an opportunity for the gospel to spread. Because of Paul's chains, the entire palace guard has heard about Christ — soldiers who would never have set foot in a church are now hearing the gospel during their guard shifts. Other believers, seeing Paul's courage, have become bold enough to speak about their faith too. Paul reframes his suffering not as a setback but as a strategy. This is a radical perspective: your worst circumstances might be God's best platform. The very thing that looks like defeat might be the vehicle God uses to accomplish something extraordinary.

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(Pawlos zisdemim awaj yi'wuj: "Ziweredeni neger biHaqi nimi'ibay wengel agelgilu iyu." HisebO. Ma'isertu agedasi aykonen wey siqay bah zibil iyu aybilin zelo. Amlak ts'ela'itu nikhfu'e ziHasebwo wesidu wengel kizrigaH ni'idil kem ziqeyero yibil alo. Bisenki senselat Pawlos kulu halewa bete-mengisti biza'iba Kristos semi'u — fets'imom nab betekristyan zeyim'atwu serawit ab nay halewa lewTom wengel yism'u alewu.)

(Ni'ay minbar Kristos iyu mimwat dima rebHa iyu. Iza hanti hareg biza'iba hiywetin motin zitets'aHfe ziblets'e sur-neqel qal titkewn tikhil. Pawlos milu'e hilawu'u ab Kristos zitewedebe mik'anu yibil — minbar ziyada nay migilgal idilat malet iyu, mimwat dima gets' nigets' misu mik'an malet iyu. Ab mengo kilte temeqiyu alo, mis Kristos kikewin kikeyd yideli — "bizuH ziblets'e" zikone — gina Filipi gena kemzidliywom yifeliT.)

Scene 6 of 25

[PICTURE: A group of young Philippian believers standing shoulder to shoulder in a Roman marketplace, facing opposition from merchants and officials who look angry. The believers hold firm together, unified and unafraid, with determined expressions. A banner of light connects them symbolically. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Whatever happens, conduct yourselves in a manner worthy of the gospel of Christ... stand firm in the one Spirit, striving together as one for the faith of the gospel without being frightened in any way by those who oppose you." Paul urges the Philippians to live lives that match the gospel they believe. It's not enough to believe the right things — you must live them out. And notice the emphasis on togetherness: "striving together as one." Faith is not a solo sport. You need others standing beside you, especially when opposition comes. Paul tells them not to be frightened by their opponents. Why? Because opposition from the world is actually evidence that you're on the right path. When the world has nothing against you, it might mean you're not living distinctly enough. Standing firm together — this is how the early church survived and thrived, and it's how you will too.

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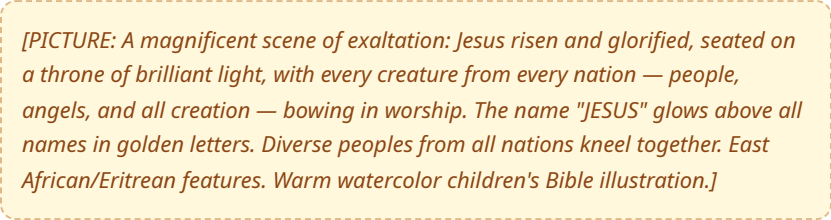
(Zikone yikun neger yimts'a'e, niwengel Kristos bizigba'e agebab temelalesu... ab hade Menfes ts'eni'ikum biHanti libi ni'imnet wengel teqalesu, biziqawemukum biminim keyferaHkum. Pawlos niFillipi aminti nizaminwo wengel zimeTaTen hiyiwet kinebru yits'uw'e. Qinu'e negerat mi'iman akhali aykonen — kitnebrO yigba'e. Ab hadnet zelo ats'in'ot astebhil: "kem hade biHabar teqalesu." Imnet nay beiyiniKha sport aykonen.)

(Ab niHadihidkum zimdnatat kem Yesus Kristos zibele ateHasasba yihalukum. Pawlos hiji ab kulu qidus ts'Huf kab zi'amequ ts'Hufat hade yeqrib — nay Kristos mezmur nay Filipi 2. Ni'aminti yinigrom: kab hilik wey kentu ti'ibit wala hanti aytigberu. Ab kindi'u bitiHtina niKhali'ot kab ri'iskum nila'ili akbiru, nay ri'iskum rebHa zeykone nay kali'ot rebHa Timtu.)

(Nisu bibahri Amlak kinsu mis Amlak ma'ire mik'an ziminTelelu koyinu aywesdon; ab kindi'u ri'su bado gebere bahri gilya bimiwsad bimisli seb tefeTre. Kristos ri'su bado gebere. Iti grikawî qal "kenosis" iyu — ri'su afse. FeTari kulu alem ab wishiTû fîTur kikewin meretse. Galaksitat biqalu zifeTere fets'imu kizareb zeykhil Hits'an kikewin meretse. Izi bigid zitegberelu aykonen — ba'ilu meretse.)

semay nab mebl'e insisa. Kab mebl'e insisa nab nay ts'erabi iyo bota. Kab iyo bota nab tenqesaqasi agelgilot. Kab agelgilot nab Tilmēt. Kab Tilmēt nab firdi. Kab firdi nab siqay. Kab siqay nab mesqel — Roma zimahazetO ziblets'e hafret zimela'on zikhifa'en mot.)

Scene 10 of 25



"Therefore God exalted him to the highest place and gave him the name that is above every name, that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, and every tongue acknowledge that Jesus Christ is Lord." Here is the great reversal: the one who went lowest is lifted highest. The one who emptied Himself is filled with all authority. The one who served is crowned as Lord of all. This is God's pattern throughout Scripture: humility precedes honor, death precedes resurrection, service precedes authority. Every knee will bow — not because God forces worship, but because when every eye sees the full truth of who Jesus is and what He did, worship will be the only reasonable response. The path to exaltation always goes through humility. If you want to be great in God's kingdom, learn to be the servant of all.

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*(Slezi Amlak nab zile'ale bota li'il abelo kab kulu sim nila'ili zikone sim habo, bisim
Yesus kulu birki kidnen — ab semay ab midri ab tiHti midri — kulu lisan dima Yesus
Kristos goyta mik'anu ki'imen. InhO iti abiiy lewTi: ziteHate zikede zile'ale li'il yibil.
Ri'su zibado gebere bikulu silTan yimel'e. Zegelgele goyta kulu koyinu yiKhlel.)*

Scene 11 of 25

[PICTURE: A young Eritrean teenager at a crossroads, one hand holding a Bible and the other reaching toward God represented by a warm light above. The path ahead shows choices: one direction leads to selfish ease, the other to purposeful service. The teen's face shows earnest determination mixed with reverent awe. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Continue to work out your salvation with fear and trembling." This verse is often misunderstood. Paul is not saying you earn salvation through works — he has already made clear that salvation is a gift of grace. Rather, he is saying: take your faith seriously. Work it out — like working out in a gym, exercise your salvation, stretch it, grow it, live it out in every area of your life. The "fear and trembling" is not terror but reverent awe — the recognition that what God has done in you is sacred and deserves your full attention. Don't be casual about your faith. Don't treat grace as a license to be lazy. God saved you for a purpose, and discovering and living that purpose requires effort, discipline, and intentionality. Your salvation is not just a ticket to heaven — it is a calling to be transformed here and now.

[illegible]

(DiHnetkum bɨfɾhin ra'idin fets'imu. Izi tiqsi bizuH gize bigega yirda'e. Pawlos diHnet bigibɾi tirkhbu aybilin — diHnet hiyab ts'eqa mik'anu diro ants'ebariku alo. Ab kindi'u

yibil: imnetkum bikhbidet wisedwo. Fets'imwo — kem ab jim misilTan, diHnetkum asilTinu, siHbwo, a'ibiywo, ab kulu chaf hiywetikum nibirwo. Iti "frhin ra'idin" sinbade aykonen gina kibur adnaqot — Amlak abaKha zigeberO qidusín milu'e aqalboKha zigib'on mik'anu miflat iyu.)

Scene 12 of 25

[PICTURE: A beautiful image of divine partnership: God's large hands gently cupping a young person's hands from behind as they work together — planting seeds in rich soil. Light flows from above into the teen's heart, and from the heart into their hands, and from their hands into the earth. Growth sprouts wherever they touch. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"For it is God who works in you to will and to act in order to fulfill his good purpose." This is the beautiful balance to the previous verse. Yes, you must work out your salvation — but you are not working alone! God Himself is at work inside you, giving you both the desire and the power to do what pleases Him. This is divine partnership: you act, and God empowers. You choose, and God enables. You cannot say, "I'll just sit back and let God do everything" — that's laziness disguised as faith. But you also cannot say, "It's all up to me" — that's pride disguised as responsibility. The Christian life is a dance between divine sovereignty and human responsibility. God provides the music, the rhythm, and the strength — but you must choose to step onto the dance floor. Every good desire in your heart? God planted it. Every act of obedience? God empowered it. You are never working for God alone — you are always working with God.

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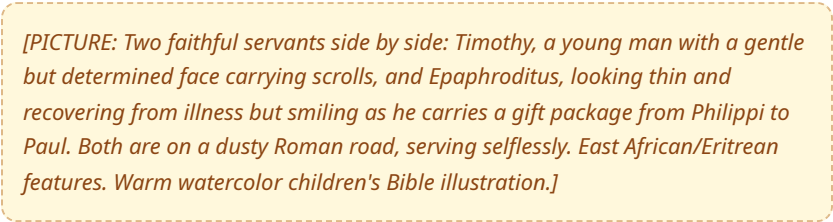
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(Amlak iyu senay fiqadu nimfjts'am kitdelyun kitgibirun abaKhatkum ziseriH zelo. Izi nay qidmi'u tiqsi ts'ibuq mizan iyu. Iwe diHnetkum kitfets'imu yigba'e — gina beynikum aytisirHun! Amlak ba'ilu ab wishiTkum yiseriH, zeHaguso kitgibiru diletin hayilin kilti'u yhibekum. Izi nay Amlak shirk'net iyu: niski tigbir Amlak dima hayili yhib. Niski timrets' Amlak dima yikhileKa.)

*(Bizey migurmramín mikirikharin kulu giberu, ab Tewi ewi weledo nits'uhatín
ts'iruyatín bizey neqefeta deqi Amlak kitkonu. DiHri'u ab ma'ikalem kem kewakhibti
ab semay kitbirhú ikum. Pawlos aminti filiyu kikhonu yits'uw'e — bigihud bizey
TirTare filiyu. Nifiluynét zible zeykone gina bisenaynet zibrih ab biri'se-fiqri zits'elmete
alem.)*

Scene 14 of 25



Paul highlights two examples of Christ-like service: Timothy and Epaphroditus. About Timothy, Paul says something heartbreaking: "I have no one else like him, who will show genuine concern for your welfare. For everyone looks out for their own interests, not those of Jesus Christ." In a world of self-interest, Timothy was rare — a person who genuinely cared about others more than himself. And Epaphroditus — this faithful man traveled from Philippi to bring Paul supplies and care for him in prison. He became so ill he nearly died, and when he recovered, his first concern was not for himself but that the Philippians had heard about his illness and were worried. These two men embody the "mind of Christ" Paul described earlier — they lived it, not just believed it. Faithful service rarely makes headlines, but it changes the world one person at a time.

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(Pawlos kilte abnitat Kristosawi agelgilot yiTqis: Timotewosín Epafroditosín. Biza'iba Timotewos Pawlos libi zisebir neger yibil: "Kema'u zibele biHaqi niTiqimkum zigdes kali'e yebileyín. Kulom nay ri'som rebHa iyom zideliyu'mber nay Yesus Kristos aykonen." Ab alem ri'se-rebHa Timotewos fluiy nebere — kab ri'su nila'ili biHaqi nikhali'ot zigdes seb.)

Scene 15 of 25

[PICTURE: Paul dramatically tossing away his impressive credentials — scrolls of education, Pharisee robes, certificates of achievement, family lineage documents — all falling into a heap labeled "rubbish." His hands are open and empty, reaching instead toward a glowing figure of Christ ahead of him. His face shows freedom and determination. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"But whatever were gains to me I now consider loss for the sake of Christ. What is more, I consider everything a loss because of the surpassing worth of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord, for whose sake I have lost all things. I consider them garbage, that I may gain Christ." Paul had an impressive resume: circumcised on the eighth day, of the tribe of Benjamin, a Hebrew of Hebrews, a Pharisee, zealous, and faultless regarding the law. By every worldly measure, he was successful. But he counts it all as garbage — the Greek word is "skubalon," meaning refuse, dung, worthless trash — compared to knowing Christ. This challenges every teenager building their identity on grades, achievements, popularity, or family status. None of these things are bad, but when they become your foundation rather than Christ, you are building on garbage. What does your identity rest on? What would you be if everything you've achieved was stripped away?

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(Gina ni'ay rebHa zinebere kulu mi'inti Kristos kisara geyre qoTserkewo. Ab li'li'u dima goytay Yesus Kristos nimiflat zili'ili waga sle zelewō kulu kisara iye ziḡoTs'ro. NiKristos kirekHbo goHaf iye ziḡoTs'ro. Pawlos zidenḡi nay hiyiwet tarikh nebero: ab shamunay me'alti zitigezre, kab neged Biniyam, ibrawi kab ibrawyan, Ferisawi, qena'i, biHigi nits'uh.)

Scene 16 of 25

[PICTURE: Two contrasting images side by side: on the left, a teenager reading a thick book ABOUT Jesus — studying facts, dates, theology — at a desk piled with books, looking bored. On the right, the same teenager walking and talking with Jesus as a close friend on a sunlit path, animated and joyful. The contrast between knowing about and knowing personally. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

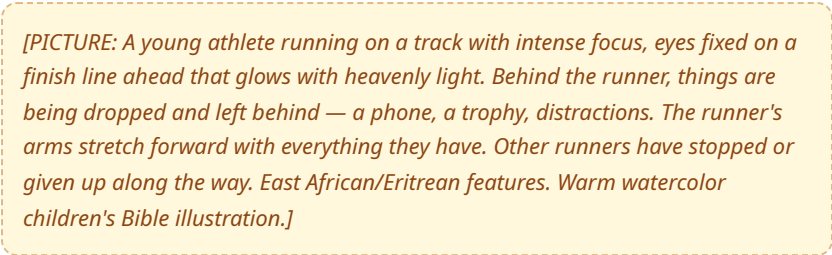
"I want to know Christ — yes, to know the power of his resurrection and participation in his sufferings, becoming like him in his death." There is a vast difference between knowing about someone and actually knowing them. You can read every biography of a famous person and still not know them at all. Paul doesn't say "I want to know more theology about Christ" — he says "I want to know HIM." This is relationship, not religion. It is intimacy, not information. Paul wants three things: to know Christ's resurrection power — the same power that raised Jesus from the dead working in his daily life; to share in Christ's sufferings — willingly entering into hardship for the sake of the gospel; and to become like Christ in His death — dying to self daily. Knowing Christ is not a subject to study — it is a person to encounter, a relationship to cultivate, a presence to experience every single day.

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(NiKristos kifelTo delye — iwe nay tinsa'e'u hayili kifeliT, ab siqayu kisatef, bimotu kimesil. Biza'iba hade seb miflatin biHaqi miflaTun ab mengo abiiy fililiy alo. Nay hade ziTef'e seb kulu nay hiyiwet tarikh kitenibib tikhil gina fets'imka aytfelTon iKha. Pawlos "biza'iba Kristos ziyada sine-melekot kifeliT delye" aybilin — "ni'u kifelTo delye" yibil. Izi zimdna iyu haymanot aykonen. Qirbet iyu habereta aykonen.)

Scene 17 of 25



"Not that I have already obtained all this, or have already arrived at my goal, but I press on to take hold of that for which Christ Jesus took hold of me. Brothers and sisters, I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it. But one thing I do: Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, I press on toward the goal to win the prize for which God has called me heavenward in Christ Jesus." Paul — the greatest apostle, the man who wrote half the New Testament — says he hasn't arrived yet. He is still pressing, still straining, still reaching. This should both humble us and encourage us. If Paul wasn't finished growing, neither are we. And if Paul kept pressing forward despite his failures, so can we. Two actions: forget what's behind — stop living in your past failures or resting on past successes. And strain toward what's ahead — spiritual ambition is holy. Want more of God. Press harder. Don't settle.

"I have not yet obtained all this, nor have I reached my goal, but I press on to take hold of that for which Christ Jesus took hold of me. Brothers and sisters, I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it. But one thing I do: Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, I press on toward the goal to win the prize for which God has called me heavenward in Christ Jesus." Paul — the greatest apostle, the man who wrote half the New Testament — says he hasn't arrived yet. He is still pressing, still straining, still reaching. This should both humble us and encourage us. If Paul wasn't finished growing, neither are we. And if Paul kept pressing forward despite his failures, so can we. Two actions: forget what's behind — stop living in your past failures or resting on past successes. And strain toward what's ahead — spiritual ambition is holy. Want more of God. Press harder. Don't settle.

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(Izi diro rekhibe'yo wey diro nab ilamay bets'iHe aykonen, gina Kristos Yesus ziHazeni
 kiHiz niqidmit yits'i'ir alekhu. AHwatey diro kem ziHazkiwo ayqoTsin. Gina hade
 neger egibir: diHrit zelo resi'e niqidmit zelo temetiTe, Amlak biKristos Yesus nisemay
 zits'ew'ani shilmot nimirikab nab ilama yits'i'ir alekhu.)

ገና ደግነቴና ልብ ወለድህን ለእኛ ግድም ሆኖ ተገኝቷል። — ለእኛ ግድም ሆኖ
ገና ደግነቴና ለእኛ ግድም ሆኖ ተገኝቷል።

*(Gina zegnetna ab semay iya. Kab'u medHani goyta Yesus Kristos bihanqewta nits'be
alena. Pawlos kilte agebatat nabra yinets'ats'er: "AmlakHom kebdom" "a'imro'om ab
midrawi neger" zikhonu ants'ar nay kali'e mengisti zegatat mik'anom zifeliTu. Kemzi
HisebO: kab Haqenya adiKha riHiqka ab wets'a'i tinbir aleKha.)*

[PICTURE: A joyful celebration scene: Paul in his prison cell with arms raised in worship, face beaming with supernatural joy. Musical notes and warm golden light fill the dark cell. The word "REJOICE" appears in both English and Tigrinya glowing around him. Guards look bewildered at his inexplicable happiness. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Rejoice in the Lord always. I will say it again: Rejoice!" Paul commands joy — twice. This is not a suggestion; it is an imperative. And notice where this command comes from: a man in chains, facing possible execution. If joy depended on circumstances, Paul would have no right to command it. But joy is not about circumstances — it is about the Lord. "Rejoice IN THE LORD" — your joy is found in who God is, not in what is happening to you. Happiness says, "I feel good because things are going well." Joy says, "I feel anchored because God is still God regardless of what's happening." Paul repeats it because we need to hear it twice: Rejoice. And in case you didn't catch it the first time — Rejoice! This is a choice, not a feeling. It is a discipline, not a mood. You can choose joy in the middle of your hardest season because joy's source never changes.

"Оо оо оооо ооооо оо оооо ооо оооо!" оооо ооо оооо — ооо ооо оо ооо ооооо оооо ооо ооо оо оооо ооооооо оооооо оооооо оо оооо ооо ооо оо оооо ооооо ооооооо оооо оооо ооо ооооооо оооо оо оооо оооо ооооо — оооо ооо ооо "ооооо оооо" — оооо оо оооо оо ооо оооо'ооо оо оооо оо ооооооо ооо "ооооо ооо оо оооо ооо ооооо" оооо ооо "ооо ооо ооооооо оооо оо оооо оо ооо ооо ооо ооооо" оооо оооо оооо ооооо ооо оо ооооо оо ооооооо ооооо оо ооооооооооо — оооо! оо ооо оо оооо ооооооо оо-оооо оо ооо ооооооо

(Kulu gize bigoyta teHagosu. Kem biHadish kiblo teHagosu! Pawlos Hagos yi'iziz — kilte gize. Izi lebewa aykonen ti'izaz iyu. Kabey kemzimts'e astebhil: bisenselat zite'asire, mot zits'beyo seb. Hagos ab kunetat zimirkos intezkewin Pawlos ki'izizo mesel ayhlwon neyru. Gina Hagos biza'iba kunetat aykonen — biza'iba goyta iyu. "Bigoyta teHagosu" — HagosKa ab Amlak men mik'anu yirkeb'imber ab zikewin zelo aykonen.)

Scene 20 of 25

[PICTURE: A young person kneeling in prayer with anxious thoughts represented as dark storm clouds above their head. As they pray, the clouds part and a gentle dove descends carrying an olive branch, representing God's peace. A protective shield of light surrounds their heart and mind. The transformation from anxiety to peace is visible. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in every situation, by prayer and petition, with thanksgiving, present your requests to God. And the peace of God, which transcends all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus." In a generation plagued by anxiety, these words are medicine. Paul's prescription for worry is not "try harder to be calm" or "just think positive." It is prayer — honest, specific, grateful prayer. Bring everything to God: your fears, your needs, your uncertainties. And do it with thanksgiving, because gratitude shifts your focus from what you lack to what you have. The result? Peace that "transcends all understanding" — peace that doesn't make logical sense given your circumstances. Peace that guards your heart like a soldier guarding a fortress. This peace is not the absence of problems; it is the presence of God in the midst of them.

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ἡμεῖς οὖν ὡς ἔχουσιν ὑμεῖς ὡς ἔχουσιν ἡμεῖς — ὡς ἡμεῖς οὖν ὡς ἔχουσιν
ὑμεῖς ὡς ἔχουσιν

*(Biza'iba wala hanti aytijhenequ, ab kulu kunetat gina bits'elotín limanon mis
misgana Tilebatkum ni'Amlak aqribu. Selam Amlak kab kulu mirda'e nila'ili zikone
libkumín a'imrokumín ab Kristos Yesus kiHilwo iyu. Ab bijhinqet zitiTeq'e weledo izi
qalat medHanit iyu. Nay Pawlos nijhinqet fewsi "hidu'e kitkewn ts'i'ar" wey "awentawi
tiray Hiseb" aykonen. Ts'elot iyu — qinu'e, fluiy, amesgani ts'elot.)*

Scene 21 of 25

[PICTURE: A teenager's mind represented as a garden with two gates. Through one gate, beautiful things enter — truth, nobility, purity, loveliness — represented as flowers, light, and clean water. Through the other gate, dark things try to enter — lies, impurity, ugliness — but the teen stands as gatekeeper, choosing what to let in. The garden of the mind flourishes with good things. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Finally, brothers and sisters, whatever is true, whatever is noble, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable — if anything is excellent or praiseworthy — think about such things." Paul gives us a filter for our thought life. In an age of endless information, social media, and content that floods your mind every waking moment, this verse is a survival guide. You become what you think about. Your thoughts shape your character, your decisions, your relationships, and your future. Paul doesn't say "never think about hard things" — he says make excellence your default. When you have a choice about what to dwell on, choose truth over lies, nobility over pettiness, purity over corruption, beauty over ugliness. Guard your mind like a fortress, because every thought is a seed. What you plant in the garden of your mind today, you will harvest in your character tomorrow. You are the gatekeeper of your own mind — choose wisely what you let in.

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*(Ab meweda'eta aHwatey zikone Haqi zikone kibur zikone qinu'e zikone nits'uh zikone
tefetawi zikone ts'ibuaq ziwreyelú — zikone biluts' wey zimisgen intehaliyu — biza'iba
kemzi'om negerat Hisebu. Pawlos ninay Hasab hiywetna filter yhibena. Ab zemen
zeywda'e habereta, maHberawi medya, kulu gize biniqHat zeLeKhalu a'imroKha
ziZanbo tiHizto — izi tiqsi nay midHan memriHi iyu. ZiHasbo tikewin.)*

Scene 22 of 25

[PICTURE: A young person standing confidently on a high cliff edge facing a fierce storm — winds blowing, waves crashing below, lightning in the sky — yet they stand firm with roots of light extending from their feet deep into the rock. A gentle glow of Christ's presence surrounds them like armor. The verse "I can do all things" is carved into the rock beneath their feet. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"I can do all this through him who gives me strength." This is one of the most quoted and most misquoted verses in the Bible. It does not mean you can achieve any worldly ambition if you pray hard enough. It does not mean God will make you win every game or ace every test. Read it in context: Paul has just said he knows what it is to be in need and what it is to have plenty, to be well-fed and to be hungry, to have abundance and to suffer want. "I can do ALL THIS" — meaning I can endure any circumstance, face any hardship, navigate any situation — through Christ who strengthens me. This is not a verse about getting what you want; it is a verse about being unshakeable regardless of what you get. Christ's strength is not a genie granting wishes — it is an anchor holding you steady when the storm rages. Whatever you face today, His strength is sufficient.

[illegible]

*(Hayili nizhibeni biKristos kulu neger kigibir ikhil iye. Izi ab metsiHaf qidus kab zibezH
ziTqesín bigega ziTqesín tiqistat hade iyu. BizuH inte tselekHa zikone alemawi
shewhat kite'ewit tikhil malet aykonen. Amlak kulu ts'eweta kitiwet wey kulu fetena
kitiHalif kigibir malet aykonen. Ab Hasabu anbibO: Pawlos si'ine kemzifeliT ab bizHi
kemzifeliT, ts'igab Timet bizHi si'inet kemzifeliT gena ilu.)*

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(Ab zikone kunetat igub kikewin mistiir temaHire — ts'igab yikun Timet, bizHi yikun si'inet. "TemahHire" zibil qal astebhil. Igbet bahriyawɪ aykonen — zirikeb iyu. Pawlos hade me'alti bi'awtomatik igub koyinu aytense'en; bitemekuro, biwdiqet, bilimimid temaHiru. Kulu gize ziyada kemzidliyeKa zinegireKa nay shemati bahli — ziyada tekhetelti, ziyada nibret, ziyada temekuro, ziyada awet — ab wishiTɔ igbet sewrawi iyu.)

በጥሩ ምርት ለማግኘት የሚያስፈልጉትን ምርቶች በዚህ ምረቃ ምርጫ ማግኘት ይቻላል።

(AmlakHey dima kekan habti kibru biKristos Yesus kulu diletikum kimli'e iyu. Pawlos debdab'u biza grum tesfa yizazim. Qinu'enet nay qwanqwa astebhil: Amlak kulu diletikum kimle'e — kulu dilyetikum aykonen, kulu timinitikum aykonen — kulu diletikum kimle'e iyu. "Kekam habti kibru" dima ygibirO — biquT'e aykonen, bibqunTaro aykonen, kab zeywda'e nay bizHu gimja bet.)

Scene 25 of 25

[PICTURE: A young Eritrean teenager standing at a window looking out at both sunshine and storm — the weather is mixed, representing life's varied circumstances. In their hand, they hold a glowing heart representing joy that doesn't depend on the weather outside. Their reflection in the window shows them wearing a crown, representing their heavenly citizenship. A Bible lies open on the windowsill to Philippians. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

So what does this letter mean for you today? It means you can choose joy regardless of your circumstances — not because problems don't matter, but because your joy is anchored in someone bigger than your problems. It means contentment is possible even in a world that profits from your dissatisfaction. It means your identity is found in Christ, not in what you achieve or what others think of you. It means you can face any situation with strength — not your own, but His. It means humility is not weakness but the path to true greatness. It means guarding your thoughts is not optional but essential. And it means you are never alone — God is working in you, providing for you, and holding you steady through every storm. Paul wrote this letter from prison, yet it overflows with joy. If he found joy in chains, you can find it in your classroom, your home, your struggles, and your uncertainties. The secret is not in your circumstances changing — it is in your source never changing. Christ is the same yesterday, today, and forever. And in Him, joy is always possible.

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*(Slezi iza debdabe lomi ni'aKha intay turgum alewa? Bizeyegeds kunetatKa Hagos
 kitmirets' tikhil malet iyu — tsegamat agedasi sle zeykonu zeykone HagosKa kab
 tsegamatKa zi'abi ab zikone sle ziteseqile. Igbet ab kab zeyigbetiKha ziribH alem'win
 zikheal malet iyu. MininnetKa ab Kristos yirikeb'imber ab zi'awetiKayo wey kali'ot
 biza'ibaKha ziHasibwo aykonen malet iyu.)*

The Moral of the Story

Joy is not the absence of suffering — it is the presence of Christ in the midst of it. Paul wrote Philippians from prison, yet this letter contains more references to joy than any other book in the New Testament relative to its length. His secret was not denial of pain but a deep rootedness in something pain could not touch: his relationship with Christ. Joy is a choice, a discipline, and a gift all at once.

The world tells you that contentment comes from having more, that identity comes from achievement, that strength comes from self-sufficiency, and that happiness depends on circumstances. Paul's letter demolishes all of these lies. True contentment is learned through trusting God in every situation. True identity is found in Christ alone. True strength flows from admitting weakness and leaning on divine power. And true joy transcends circumstances because it is rooted in the unchanging character of God.

You are called to live with the mind of Christ — humble, selfless, and servant-hearted. You are called to press forward toward God's purpose, forgetting past failures and reaching for future faithfulness. You are called to guard your thoughts, choose gratitude, and shine like stars in a dark world. And you can do all of this — not through your own power, but through Christ who strengthens you. Whatever you face today, His joy is available, His peace is offered, and His strength is sufficient.

Key Verse: "I can do all this through him who gives me strength." — Philippians 4:13

אני אכלה כל זה דרך ה' אשר נותן לי כח — פיליפיים 4:13

Discussion Questions

1. What is the difference between joy and happiness? Paul commands us to "rejoice always" — is this realistic? How can joy coexist with sadness, grief, or pain? Think of a time when you experienced something hard but still felt an underlying peace — what made that possible?

1. 你 知道 快乐 和 喜悦 的 区别 吗? 保罗 "要 常常 喜乐" 的 命令 — 是 否 很 现实 呢? 你 能 在 悲伤、痛苦 或 困难 的 时候 仍然 感到 内心 的 平安 吗? 想 起 一 个 你 经历过 困难 但 仍然 感到 内心 有 一种 平静 的 时刻 — 是 什么 让 这 成为 可能 的?

2. Paul says he has "learned the secret of being content." In a consumer culture that profits from making you feel like you never have enough — enough followers, enough looks, enough success — how do you practice contentment? What specific areas of your life do you struggle with discontentment?

2. 保罗 说 他 "已经 学会 了 知足 的 秘诀"。在 一个 消费 文化 中，它 从 让你 感到 你 永远 不够 — 够 的 追随 者、够 的 外表、够 的 成功 — 你 如何 实践 知足 呢? 你 在 生活 的 哪些 具体 方面 感到 不满 呢?

3. Philippians 2 describes Christ's humility — emptying Himself, becoming a servant, dying on a cross. In an age of self-promotion and personal branding, what does genuine humility look like practically? How do you pursue excellence without falling into pride? Can you be ambitious and humble at the same time?

3. 腓立比书 2 描述了 基督 的 谦卑 — 倒 空 自己，成为 仆人，在 十字 架上 受 死。在 一个 自我 宣传 和 个人 品牌 的 时代，真正 的 谦卑 在 实际 中 是 怎么 样 的? 你 如何 在 不 陷入 骄傲 的 情况 下 追求 卓越? 你 能 同时 既 有 雄心 又 谦卑 吗?

4. Paul tells us to think about "whatever is true, noble, right, pure, lovely, and admirable." In the age of social media, endless content, and information overload, how do you practically guard your thought life? What specific habits or boundaries could you set to protect your mind? How do the things you consume shape who you are becoming?

4. "Whatever is true, noble, right, pure, lovely, and admirable." How do you guard your thought life? What specific habits or boundaries could you set to protect your mind? How do the things you consume shape who you are becoming?

5. Paul found his identity entirely in Christ — counting everything else as "garbage" compared to knowing Him. What do most teenagers today build their identity on? What happens when those foundations are shaken — when you don't get the grades, the relationship, the acceptance? How would your daily life change if your deepest identity was truly "I am in Christ" rather than "I am my achievements"?

5. Paul found his identity entirely in Christ — counting everything else as "garbage" compared to knowing Him. What do most teenagers today build their identity on? What happens when those foundations are shaken — when you don't get the grades, the relationship, the acceptance? How would your daily life change if your deepest identity was truly "I am in Christ" rather than "I am my achievements"?

A Prayer for Joy and Strength

Heavenly Father, we come before You asking for the supernatural joy that Paul experienced — joy that does not depend on our circumstances but is rooted in Your unchanging character. Teach us that happiness is a feeling but joy is a choice, and give us the courage to choose joy even in our darkest moments.

Lord, give us the mind of Christ — the humility that considers others above ourselves, the selflessness that serves without seeking recognition, the willingness to empty ourselves so that You might fill us. In a world that screams "promote yourself," help us whisper "serve others." In a culture that demands we climb higher, teach us that true greatness is found in kneeling lower.

We ask for contentment in a world designed to make us discontent. Free us from the endless cycle of wanting more — more approval, more possessions, more success — and anchor our satisfaction in You alone. Teach us that You are enough, that Your provision is sufficient, and that our worth is found in being Yours, not in what we achieve.

Guard our minds, Father. Help us to think about what is true when lies surround us, what is noble when pettiness tempts us, what is pure when impurity is normalized, and what is lovely when ugliness is celebrated. Make us gatekeepers of our own thoughts, choosing excellence over mediocrity.

And Lord, we claim Your promise: we can do all things through Christ who strengthens us. Not all things we selfishly desire, but all things You call us to. Give us strength for every circumstance — strength to endure, strength to persevere, strength to love, and strength to shine like stars

*in this dark generation. In the name of Jesus, our joy and our strength.
Amen.*

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Little Believers Tigrinya Bible Stories

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